

through the area, killing one, Tara Chand Sharma, and injuring 10 others. Sharma leaves behind a widow, six daughters and a teenaged son. Within 20 minutes of the first blast, eight other bombs went off along a 3 km stretch, leaving a trail of death and destruction. Sixty three people died, Muslims and Hindus, who lived side by side.

Two hundred were injured, among them Naresh Saini, 27, a flower seller who makes garlands for devotees at another Hanuman temple near Kotwali police station. He picked up two victims who were bleeding before realising that he too was hit by tiny steel ball bearings packed in the explosives. He joined the hundreds of injured and dead brought to the emergency ward at Sawai Man Singh Hospital. The collective grief and shock was made grimmer by the realisation that their historic city, a tourist haven, had joined the list of targets picked by terrorists to create communal mayhem.

It was clear from the operation that the merchants of terror had planned everything meticulously after carrying out a survey of the area. They chose the crowded main road and temples which are packed on Tuesdays. The roadside parking is normally closed for vehicles but not to bicycles which, armed with bombs hidden in the carriers were used for the strikes, a strategy similar to other recent cases of terror elsewhere in the country. The state's forensic expert B.B. Arora called the bombs "sophisticated", which required a high level of ex-

pertise and were designed to cause maximum destruction. Pankaj Kumar Singh, Inspector General of Police, Jaipur, said the IED explosives were similar to the ones used in the Hyderabad terror blasts.

The police refuse to name any organisation at this juncture but the needle of suspicion points to HUIJI and SIMI. They picked up a rickshawpuller Vijay Kumar who was himself hurt, and who hysterically claimed he planted a device given to him by a woman. Singh said he was innocent but the identity of the woman was being looked into. Another suspect is Jalaluddin, a HUIJI activist arrested by the Uttar Pradesh police, and Mohammad Shamin, a SIMI activist who was arrested after the Ajmer blast last year and let off.

The key question is why Jaipur? "Why not Jaipur," counters a senior officer of the Rajasthan Government. "A clear pattern in blasts shows that these groups have been targeting cities to prove their pan Indian presence," he says. Jaipur has been coming up as a fast progressing city and attracts tourists from across the world. It has pockets of Muslims which helps terrorists to indoctrinate and source recruits. That the walled city was targeted indicates that attackers felt it was easy to merge into the background. The Government was quick to preempt any communal flareup by imposing curfew in areas of mixed population.

The only clues were the cycles used in the blasts. Police tracked the shop which had sold the

SHATTERED DREAMS: A bangle seller's wares scattered at a blast site

